correspondence took many days, sometimes even weeks, to reach Tezu, breaking news like this became a dilemma for me. I preferred discretion and after a few days told Rohini about it. Since she was staying in separate family accommodation in Dinjan, I did not want her to talk about it to anyone. But she told the kids. Sure enough the next day it was the news in the station that we might be posted to Mhow. After a month or so the nomination reached me through the official channel.

After completing this eventful and successful tenure of three years in Arunachal Pradesh in April 1983, the battalion moved to Binaguri (near Siliguri), to a peace station on rotation. Although initially we were disappointed to have been given a station far away from Maharashtra, there were some advantages of this too, such as adequate accommodation for the families and a central school for the children's education. The battalion settled down quickly and over a hundred families arrived to join their menfolk. It was then conveyed to us that there was an exercise in the offing for the division in the high-altitude areas of north Sikkim during May-June. All of us who were selected for the Higher Command Course were asked to report to the College of Combat (now renamed Army War College), Mhow in the first week of July after taking annual leave. My brigade commander asked me to forego leave and stay on for the exercise, and even went to the extent of saying that the higher command course would be like a year's holiday! I was perhaps the only officer who arrived at Mhow without taking a spell of leave.

The year-long higher command course was introduced after the Indo–Pak war of 1971. Its aim is to train selected colonels and equivalent ranks in the operational art of war and in the planning and conduct of operations at the corps and field army level, with special emphasis on jointmanship. It is the only course where there is no grading or report written on the officers. This has been decided consciously so that the officers can speak freely while discussing operational plans or security issues at the highest level. Once again, I was the first in my batch to do this prestigious course, with most of the others being two or three years my senior. We discussed